

Article Review #2

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Vishing and Smishing Perpetrators and Their Victims in Nigerian Slums

Adeyemo, Olabulo, and Peter (2026) went into three of the roughest slum neighborhoods in Lagos, Nigeria Ajegunle, Amukoko, and Ijora-Badia and talked to the people actually living through vishing and smishing scams. Not just the victims. The perpetrators too. That's what makes this paper different from most cybercrime research I've read. It doesn't treat fraud as a tech problem with a tech fix. It treats it as something born out of poverty, broken institutions, and the way people influence each other in tight-knit communities. The whole study is built on Routine Activity Theory from Cohen and Felson (1979), which says crime happens when you've got a motivated offender, a vulnerable target, and nobody around to stop it. In these slums? All three boxes get checked every single day.

Research Questions, Hypotheses, and Variables

This isn't a numbers-driven study, so there's no formal hypothesis being tested. The researchers were after something deeper they wanted to know what techniques scammers actually use, why they got into it, how victims react when they realize they've been tricked, and what it is about slum life that makes these crimes so common. The independent variables, if you think of them loosely, are things like poverty, peer pressure, low digital literacy, and weak policing. The dependent variables are how often people get involved in fraud, how easily victims get deceived, and whether anyone has a real way to cope with the fallout. The interviews spell out those connections better than any regression table could.

Adeyemo et al. (2026) used a qualitative cross-sectional design. They interviewed 30 people total 20 victims, 10 perpetrators found through snowball sampling, which was really the only option since active scammers aren't exactly signing up for studies. Interviews were semi-structured, ran about 45 to 60 minutes each, and were done in English or Pidgin depending on

the person. Everything was recorded, transcribed word for word, anonymized with codes, and locked down on encrypted drives.

Data and Analysis

All the data came from those interviews plus field notes the researchers kept along the way. They used content analysis — partly inductive, letting patterns show up on their own, and partly deductive, checking what they found against Routine Activity Theory. Three different researchers coded the material independently, which keeps things honest. What stands out is how many direct quotes they pulled. You're reading a scammer explain exactly how he uses burner phones and bulk SMS apps, then two pages later an elderly woman is describing the moment she realized her savings were gone. That kind of first-hand detail is hard to argue with.

Connections to Course Concepts

A few things from class jumped out at me while reading this. Social engineering is the big one, perpetrators described pretending to be bank reps and telecom workers to build trust, which is exactly the kind of authority-based manipulation we talked about in our discussions on cyber threat psychology. The mentorship culture was wild too. Experienced scammers in these neighborhoods actively recruit and train new ones, which is social learning theory playing out in real time. And the fact that victims had zero exposure to any kind of security awareness training ties straight back to what we've covered about the human side of cybersecurity being the weakest link when it's left unaddressed.

Challenges Facing Marginalized Groups

This part of the study stuck with me. These neighborhoods are some of the poorest in Lagos, and residents are caught in a brutal cycle, they're the ones getting scammed, but poverty also pushes some of them into running scams just to survive. One older woman lost everything

after responding to a fake government grant text. She didn't tell anyone for a while because she thought people would say she had no business owning a smartphone at her age. That shame keeps people quiet, crimes never get reported, and the scammers keep going. Cookie-cutter cybersecurity campaigns designed for middle-class internet users won't do a thing here. These communities need something built for them, in their language, on their terms.

Conclusion

What I took away from this paper is pretty simple. Cybersecurity isn't just about firewalls and encryption, it's about people. Adeyemo et al. (2026) put a microphone in front of scammers and their victims in some of Lagos's most desperate neighborhoods, and what came back tells you more about how fraud works than any technical report could. Poverty drives people to crime. Shame keeps victims silent. Broken institutions let the whole thing run unchecked. That's a social science problem, and it lines up with everything we've been discussing this semester.

References

Adeyemo, L. J., Olabulo, T. Y., & Peter, I. G. (2026). Vishing and smishing perpetrators and their victims in Nigerian slums. *International Journal of Cybersecurity Intelligence & Cybercrime*, 9(1), 23–43. <https://doi.org/10.52306/2578-3289.1208>

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